revolution ushered in, the decline of Russia into civil war, the betrayal of the Allied cause, the execution of Tsar Nicholas II and his family, all created a feeling of horror among most British officials. Memorandum and reports were constantly being produced by various government bodies detailing the apparent decrepitude of the Bolshevik regime.[81] The problem, however, is when anti-Bolshevism is discussed to the exclusion of all other explanations. By assuming too quickly that ideology was the sole motivator behind Britain's actions towards Russia after 1917, other facets of the topic – such as imperial concerns and the legacy of the past – are sidelined, leaving only a partial picture of affairs.

One of the reasons for this focus on anti-Bolshevism is that for those whose remit is the post-revolution period, the focus has been almost entirely on the idea of change rather than continuity. The Allied intervention,[82] the impact of Bolshevism on British Labour,[83] the Trade Agreement negotiations[84] – all of these topics have monopolised scholarly interest and come to define Anglo-Russian relations in this period. Because a significant proportion of the literature has focused on issues which had no parallel in the nineteenth or early twentieth centuries, this has left the impression that the October revolution constituted almost a complete break with the past. Anglo-Soviet relations are viewed as fundamentally different to Anglo-Russian relations, and because the transformation was due to Bolshevism, the relationship between Britain and Russia after 1917 is in turn defined by ideology. The trouble with this line of thought is that it presupposes that both countries were affected in the same measure by the events of October 1917. Yet, while the Bolshevik revolution may have been of monumental consequence to Russia, the same could not necessarily be said for Britain. This is particularly true in the early years of the revolution, when not only was there limited information on the Bolshevik regime, but there was also little expectation that Lenin and his comrades would survive as a viable government anyway.[85] For most observers among the British political elite, October 1917 was just one further upheaval in Russia's already turbulent domestic history.[86]

Any information the British government did have on the Bolshevik regime mainly focused on their domestic policies. The British representative, Robert Bruce-Lockhart, and British military personnel involved in the